Chelmsford. Curzon's imperialistic rhetoric, when it came to 'doing as Britain pleased' with Persia, is an indication of the confidence he appeared to have in Britain's capabilities in the post-war period. It also reflected, perhaps, a concept of the British Empire as a force that needed to continually expand and strengthen lest it flounder. For its part, the Indian government was more conservative in its expectations of the empire after 1918. It was more willing to accept a limited British presence in southern Asia and called for a reduction in Britain's military and financial involvement in that part of the world. In the opinion of the Indian government, it was far worse for the empire to have to face flagrant violation of unenforceable treaties, or even military defeat, than to admit its limitations and tailor its policy accordingly.

For Curzon, the post-war period provided the opportunity to extend and consolidate Britain's imperial influence in southern Asia once and for all (creating his 'Moslem nexus of states'), using all the financial and military coercion the empire could garner to forcibly achieve this position of hegemony. For Chelmsford, this was a time to resuscitate Britain's reputation among the South Asian population, to seek to find an accord with the forces of nationalism and pan-Islamism and to maintain Britain's imperial position through a more subtle form of influence, by appearing as the friend and benefactor of the Muslim world. Eventually, the course of events in the next few years would come to vindicate the Indian government's point of view. In the years 1918 to 1919, however, Delhi was doomed to play Cassandra, unable to make itself heard in London, despite the astuteness and foresight of its opinions.